Besides table salt, other sources of sodium include **sodium bicarbonate** in baking powder and baking soda, **sodium benzoate** (preservative added to sauces), **sodium citrate** (flavour enhancer), **monosodium glutamate** (MSG - additive used in Chinese cuisine), **sodium alginate** (texture enhancer in ice creams), **sodium propionate** (used in processed cheese, bread etc to inhibit growth of mold) and **sodium sulphite** (added to prevent discolouration of dried fruits).



Fig 11.3 Oedema of the feet

11.5 Sodium restricted diet

A sodium-restricted diet is a regular diet in which the amount of sodium is limited. Such a diet is used to reduce oedema and hypertension. Most individuals obtain far too much sodium from their diets. The main source of sodium is table salt. The American Heart Association (2017) recommends no more than 2,300 milligrams (mg) of sodium a day and an ideal limit of less than 1,500 mg per day especially for those with high blood pressure.

Diets that are very low in sodium must be used with caution since it may deplete the body's sodium content to dangerously low levels. Symptoms associated with low blood sodium levels **(Hyponatremia)** include weakness, cramps, lethargy, lack of appetite, nausea, irritability, restlessness, headache and confusion.

Foods that are limited or avoided in a sodium restricted diet include processed meat, processed cheese, canned food, pickles, papads, salty snacks, salted butter, soups, pizzas, sauces, salad dressings, spreads etc. Sodium content of some foods per 100 grams is given in table 11.1.

The DASH (Dietary Approaches to Stop Hypertension) diet plan is used to reduce high blood pressure. This eating plan helps to lower blood pressure by emphasizing on the intake of fruits, vegetables, and low-fat milk thus providing a generous supply of potassium, magnesium, calcium, and fibre. It includes more whole grains and less refined grains compared to a typical diet.

11.6 Dietary management and life style modification in hypertension

A critical step in the prevention and management of hypertension is adopting a healthy life style which includes the following:

1. Dietary modification:

The objectives of dietary management for hypertension are

a) To achieve a gradual weight loss in overweight and obese individuals

b) To reduce the sodium intake

c) To maintain adequate nutrition

- **Energy:** Hypertension is often controlled with weight loss in obese individuals. Therefore, energy intake should be adjusted in such a manner so as to bring about weight loss until ideal body weight is attained.
- **Protein:** Plant sources of protein such as legumes and pulses are also rich in fibre and low in sodium. Therefore, these should be included in the diet. Animal

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